

CURRICULUM ARCHITECTURE & SYSTEM DESIGN DOCUMENT

The Adaptable Musician's Framework

A Complete Music Education System — Architecture & Curriculum Plan

"Four dimensions. Two instruments. One integrated practice."

Melody OS

Harmony OS

Voicings OS

Rhythm Code OS

Synthesis

June 2026

Version 1.0 — Planning Document

SECTION 1 The Three-Book System

The AMF is organized as three connected books, each doing one specific job. The Textbook explains; the Practice Manual directs; the Workbook records. Together they form a complete learning architecture.

BOOK 1

The Adaptable Musician's Framework

The "Why and What" book

Deep theory, examples from world music history, cross-system analysis, the Convergence Matrix. Work through at your own pace — a chapter at a time. Return to it as a reference. Does not tell you what to do today; tells you how music works.

BOOK 2

AMF Daily Practice Manual

The "What to do today" book

12 monthly sprints, 1-hour sessions per instrument (Piano and Guitar). Every session sequenced so 15, 30, or 60 minutes all work. Audiation-first throughout. Spaced repetition built in. Song learning as a non-negotiable thread. Milestones at 1, 3, 6, and 12 months.

BOOK 3

AMF Workbook

The "Where I do the work" book

Analysis templates, transcription grids, composition pages, progress tracking, definition-of-done checklists. Companion to both other books. Primarily blank pages designed for writing in.

SECTION 2 The Four Dimensions of Music

Every musical moment can be described through four independent dimensions. The textbook teaches each system in depth, then reveals what happens when they interact.

Melody OS

The Emotional Map of Melody

Notes are not just pitches — they are functional labels (DO-TI) that carry emotional weight determined by their position in the key AND their relationship to the current chord.

Source: "The Emotional Map of Melody" by Tamas Bodzsar (EMM p.1-3)

Harmony OS

The Harmony Universe

Chords function in groups (Tonic / Subdominant / Dominant), create movement through ii-V-I cycles, and can borrow from parallel modes to expand emotional range.

Source: theharmonyproject.io

Voicings OS

The Texture Layer

The same chord voiced differently creates a completely different emotional experience. Guide tones, position theory (P1/P2/P3), and available tensions are the tools.

Source: theharmonyproject.io

Rhythm Code

The Time Dimension

Rhythm = starting points, not duration. The son clave — a 5-note, 2-measure pattern found in every genre — underlies most great grooves. The Rhythm Code Map shows all 16 positions rated Strong, Medium, or Avoid.

Source: "The Rhythm Code" by Tamas Bodzsar (RC p.9-121)

SECTION 3 Book 1 — Table of Contents

The textbook is organized in five parts. Each chapter includes prose teaching, diverse song examples from multiple genres, historical context sidebars, and analysis exercises. A Repertoire Assignment at the end of each chapter connects theory to a specific song to learn.

INTRODUCTION — FOUR DIMENSIONS, ONE SONG

The 4D Chord Event concept · Convergence vs. Divergence · How to use this book

PART I — THE FOUR LANGUAGES

Ch. 1 The Emotional Map of Melody (Melody OS)

Stability Ladder · Four Zones · The Two Questions · The Cake Shop Principle

♪ Repertoire: "Ain't No Sunshine" (Bill Withers)

Ch. 2 The Harmony Universe (Harmony OS)

Intervals · Triads · 7th Chords · ii-V-I · Secondary Dominants · Tritone Sub · Modal Interchange

♪ Repertoire: "Autumn Leaves" (jazz standard)

Ch. 3 The Texture Layer (Voicings OS)

Guide Tones · Position Theory · Available Tensions · Register as Modifier

♪ Repertoire: "The Girl from Ipanema" (Jobim)

Ch. 4 The Rhythm Dimension (Rhythm Code OS)

Binary Grid · Stops · Anticipations · Son Clave · Rhythm Code Map · 4-Step Groove Development

♪ Repertoire: "Superstition" (Stevie Wonder)

Ch. 5 The AMF Perception Protocol ◀ NEW

5 Layers of Listening · The AMF Checklist · Live Musical Situation Exercises

♪ Repertoire: "What's Going On" (Marvin Gaye)

PART II — THE INTERSECTIONS

Ch. 6 The Temporal Emotional Map — Melody × Rhythm

Temporal Zone Table · "Floating Through" technique · QNA+TI = maximum urgency principle

♪ Repertoire: "Hallelujah" (Leonard Cohen)

Ch. 7 Zone and Function — Melody × Harmony

Zone-Function compound emotions · Convergence vs. Divergence formalized

♪ Repertoire: "Summertime" (Gershwin)

Ch. 8 The Texture Dimension — Voicings × Melody

The Tension Stack · Register as Emotional Modifier · Guide Tone Alignment

♪ Repertoire: "My Funny Valentine"

Ch. 9 Harmonic Rhythm — Harmony × Rhythm Code

Chord changes as rhythmic events · Anticipated Harmony · Tritone Sub × Anticipation

♪ Repertoire: "Just the Two of Us"

Ch. 10 Grooves That Speak — Voicings × Rhythm Code

Rhythmic Tension Framing · Stab Voicings · Grace Notes as Micro-Anticipations · Left Hand Rhythm

♪ Repertoire: "Watermelon Man" (Herbie Hancock)

PART III — THE CONVERGENCE

Ch. 11 The 4D Chord Event

4D Event Notation · 10 worked examples

♪ Repertoire: "Blackbird" (The Beatles)

Ch. 12 The Convergence Matrix

48-combination reference tool · Voicing Modifier Table

♪ Repertoire: "I Will Always Love You"

Ch. 13 Tension Budgets — Managing All Dimensions

Tension spectrums per system · The Two-at-a-Time Principle · Progressive Tension Loading

♪ Repertoire: "Under the Bridge" (RHCP)

Ch. 14 Section Architecture in Four Dimensions

Verse / Pre-Chorus / Chorus / Bridge / Outro multi-dimensional profiles

♪ Repertoire: "Don't Know Why" (Norah Jones)

Ch. 15 The Art of Divergence

Four compositional strategies · Full Convergence · Melodic / Rhythmic / Harmonic Divergence · Full Divergence

♪ Repertoire: "Feeling Good" (Nina Simone)

PART IV — CREATIVE APPLICATION

Ch. 16 The Four-Dimensional Composition Process

7-step creative workflow

♪ Repertoire: "Yesterday" (The Beatles)

Ch. 17 Analysis as Composition

Three fully-worked 4D analyses

♪ Repertoire: "High and Dry" (Radiohead)

Ch. 18 Improvisation in Four Dimensions

Zone-of-the-Moment Tracking · Rhythm Code in real-time · The Conversation Model

♪ Repertoire: "Fly Me to the Moon"

PART V — WORKSHOPS

10 guided composition workshops · From single-system drills to the full AMF Composition capstone

PART VI — REPERTOIRE BUILDING

The AMF Starter Repertoire — 20 songs across 6 genres, mapped to chapters · "Oddballs Worth Knowing" sidebar list

APPENDICES

A: The Convergence Matrix (full reference) · B: Rhythm Code Map · C: Zone-Chord Quick Reference · D: Section Design Quick Reference · E: Concept-to-Source Index (page citations) · F: Supporting Materials Index · G: AMF Perception Checklist (field use) · H: Repertoire Progress Tracker

Module 5 Placeholder: An explicit open slot for a fifth foundational system. All cross-system chapters designed to accept it. Exercises marked ▲ will be updated when the fifth system is defined.

One Hour Per Instrument. Sequenced by Priority.

Each session is structured so that stopping at 15, 30, or 60 minutes always means you did the most important work first. Piano and Guitar are separate 1-hour plans — you can do one per day, both, or alternate by day.

Priority	Time Block	If You Have...	What You Do
Priority 1	Minutes 0–15	15 min or more	Ear Training (audiation drill) · Quick song phrase · Spaced review of one past concept
Priority 2	Minutes 15–30	30 min or more	Technical drill for today's concept (instrument-specific) · Voicing or chord shape work
Priority 3	Minutes 30–45	45 min or more	Full current repertoire song · Work problem sections · Sight-reading one new phrase
Priority 4	Minutes 45–60	Full hour	Free improvisation/exploration with today's concept · Documentation (what you discovered)

Piano Session vs. Guitar Session — Key Differences

Piano

- Voicings in both hands — chord spread, register, pedaling
- Left hand rhythm follows Rhythm Code clave
- Tensions voiced explicitly across keys
- Improvisation: zone-based right-hand melody over left-hand vamp
- Ear training focus: hear voicing quality before playing

Guitar

- Chord shapes, capo use, barre vs. open positions
- Strumming/fingerpicking pattern carries the groove
- Tensions implied through partial shapes and melody notes
- Lead playing: zone navigation on the fretboard
- Ear training focus: hear the melody and find it on the neck

SECTION 5 **Three Definitions of Done**

Not all skills are learned the same way. Some things require strict mastery before moving forward. Others are lifelong practices where the goal is measurable growth, not perfection. And repertoire has its own standard — performance readiness.

DEFINITION OF DONE TYPE 1

Mastery (Strict)

✓ **Must achieve
before progressing**

These are foundational, discrete skills where precision matters. You either can do it or you can't. Examples: identifying all 7 scale degrees by ear in real time, playing a ii-V-I with correct voicings in 3 keys, clapping the 2-3 and 3-2 son clave accurately.

Standard: "Can perform this correctly and consistently, 9 out of 10 attempts, without hesitation, in multiple keys."

What "done" looks

like: A specific, testable action you perform and pass.

DEFINITION OF DONE TYPE 2

Progressive (Growth)

↑ **Measured by
growth over time**

These are complex, integrated skills that are never "finished" — they deepen over a lifetime. Examples: inner ear → instrument transfer speed, improvisation quality, zone awareness while playing, creative use of divergence.

Standard: "At minimum, you should be able to [specific observable behavior]. Full fluency develops over months and years."

What "done" looks

like: A minimum bar for each time period (1 month, 3 months, 6 months, 1 year), with honest acknowledgment that the skill continues to deepen.

DEFINITION OF DONE TYPE 3

Performance Ready

♪ **Ready for a real
audience**

For repertoire songs. The standard is not theoretical knowledge of the song — it's the ability to perform it live.

Standard: "Can play the complete song from memory, at a comfortable tempo, in front of another person, without stopping to correct mistakes. Transitions are smooth. The song communicates emotionally."

What "done" looks

like: You've played it for someone. Even once. Even informally.

SECTION 6 The AMF Year — 12 Monthly Sprints

The year is divided into 12 monthly sprints. Each sprint has a specific focus, a daily practice theme, and a repertoire target. Milestone checkpoints at months 1, 3, 6, and 12 assess real-world progress across all three Definition-of-Done types.

Sprint	Month	Focus	Repertoire Target
Sprint 1	Month 1	Melody OS + Inner Ear Foundations	Ain't No Sunshine + What's Going On
Sprint 2	Month 2	Rhythm Code OS + Groove	Superstition + Hallelujah
Sprint 3	Month 3	★ MILESTONE 1 + Harmony OS Foundations	Autumn Leaves + Summertime
Sprint 4	Month 4	Harmony OS Deep + Repertoire Push	Just the Two of Us + Yesterday
Sprint 5	Month 5	Voicings OS + Texture	Girl from Ipanema + My Funny Valentine
Sprint 6	Month 6	★ MILESTONE 2 + Melody × Rhythm	Blackbird + Watermelon Man
Sprint 7	Month 7	Zone × Function Intersection	Feeling Good + Under the Bridge
Sprint 8	Month 8	Harmonic Rhythm + Voicings × Melody	Don't Know Why + High and Dry
Sprint 9	Month 9	All Intersections + 4D Events	I Will Always Love You + Fly Me to the Moon
Sprint 10	Month 10	Convergence + Tension Budgets	+2 songs of choice
Sprint 11	Month 11	Composition + Section Architecture	+2 songs of choice
Sprint 12	Month 12	★ MILESTONE 4 + Integration + Repertoire Completion	Full 20-song repertoire review

★ = Milestone month

SECTION 7 Milestone Checkpoints

These are not tests. They are honest calibration points — a structured self-assessment to confirm where you are and what to focus on next.

Milestone 1

End of Month 1

MASTERY CHECKS

- ✓ Can sing the Stability Ladder (DO-SO-MI-LA-RE-TI-FA) from memory, in any key
- ✓ Can label any of the 7 scale degrees by its zone without hesitation
- ✓ Can clap both the 2-3 and 3-2 son clave accurately over a recording
- ✓ Can identify chord function (Tonic / Subdominant / Dominant) in a simple 4-chord loop

PROGRESSIVE MINIMUMS

- ↑ Can play "Ain't No Sunshine" beginning to end without stopping (even slowly)
- ↑ Has noticed at least one moment of zone-rhythm interaction while listening
- ↑ Has applied the AMF Perception Protocol (all 5 layers) to at least 2 songs

REPERTOIRE

- ♪ "Ain't No Sunshine" — Performance Ready
- ♪ "What's Going On" — can play/sing through, not yet performance ready

Milestone 2

End of Month 3

MASTERY CHECKS

- ✓ Can identify the clave orientation (2-3 or 3-2) in any anchor song by ear
- ✓ Can play a ii-V-I with correct 7th chord voicings in 3 keys on piano
- ✓ Can play the same ii-V-I cleanly on guitar in 2 keys
- ✓ Can identify secondary dominants and tritone substitutions by ear

PROGRESSIVE MINIMUMS

- ↑ Inner ear → instrument: hear a zone and find it within 5 seconds
- ↑ Can describe any important note as a 2D event (Zone / Function)
- ↑ Has completed Textbook Chapters 1-5

REPERTOIRE (5 SONGS PERFORMANCE-READY)

- ♪ Ain't No Sunshine · Superstition · Hallelujah
- ♪ Autumn Leaves · What's Going On

Milestone 3

End of Month 6

MASTERY CHECKS

Milestone 4

End of Month 12

MASTERY CHECKS

- ✓ Can describe any musical moment as a complete 4D Event (Zone / Function / Voicing / Rhythm position)
- ✓ Can complete the full 5-layer AMF Perception Protocol within 3 minutes
- ✓ Can play guide-tone voicings (3rd + 7th) for any chord type in any key on piano

PROGRESSIVE MINIMUMS

- ↑ Inner ear → instrument: hear a phrase in your head and find it without notation
- ↑ Can improvise a 4-bar melody that uses at least 2 different zones consciously
- ↑ Has completed Textbook Chapters 1–10

REPERTOIRE (10 SONGS PERFORMANCE-READY)

- ♪ All Month 1–3 songs, plus: Just the Two of Us · Yesterday
- ♪ Girl from Ipanema · My Funny Valentine · Blackbird · Watermelon Man

- ✓ Can improvise meaningfully over any repertoire song using zone awareness consciously
- ✓ Can compose an 8-bar section using the 7-step 4D Composition Process and explain every decision
- ✓ Can play all 20 repertoire songs on at least one instrument

PROGRESSIVE MINIMUMS

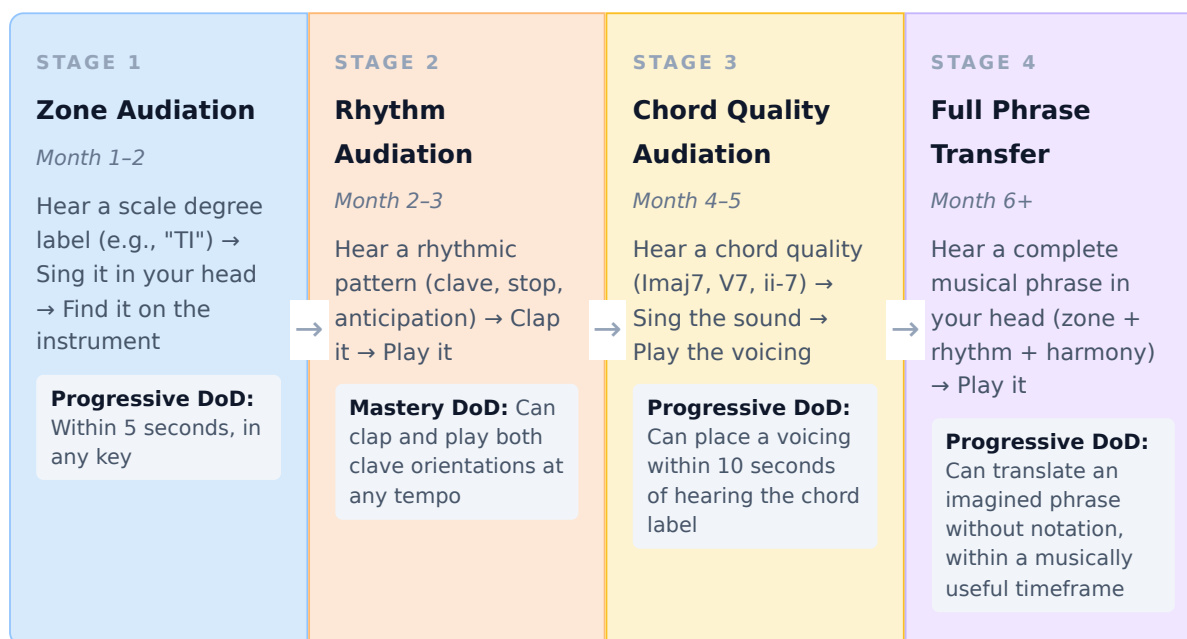
- ↑ Inner ear → instrument: hear a chord voicing with tension color and play it within seconds
- ↑ Can identify harmonic-rhythmic framework in a live situation within 60 seconds
- ↑ Has completed all 18 Textbook chapters + at least 5 of 10 Workshops

REPERTOIRE (20 SONGS)

- ♪ All 20 AMF Starter Repertoire songs — minimum 15 performance-ready
- ♪ At least 2 "Oddballs" from the Expand list

SECTION 8 The Core Skill — Inner Ear to Instrument

One of the most consistently underdeveloped skills in musicians who learn theoretically is audiation transfer — the ability to hear a musical idea in your head and immediately play it on the instrument. The AMF Practice Manual addresses this directly. It is the one thread that runs through every single session, every sprint, every month.



SECTION 9 The AMF Starter Repertoire — 20 Songs

One song per chapter, built progressively over the year. No country in the performance repertoire (though country examples may appear in the textbook). Genre diversity is intentional — by the end of the year you should be comfortable moving between folk, R&B, blues, jazz, rock, and world music contexts.

#	Song	Artist	Genre	Ch.	Primary Principle	Sprint
1	Ain't No Sunshine	Bill Withers	Soul/R&B	1	Zone awareness	Sprint 1
2	Autumn Leaves	Jazz standard	Jazz	2	Harmonic function	Sprint 3
3	The Girl from Ipanema	Jobim	Brazilian/Jazz	3	Voicing tensions	Sprint 5
4	Superstition	Stevie Wonder	Funk/Soul	4	Son Clave groove	Sprint 2
5	What's Going On	Marvin Gaye	Soul/R&B	5	Full perception	Sprint 1
6	Hallelujah	Leonard Cohen	Folk/Rock	6	Zone x rhythm	Sprint 2
7	Summertime	Gershwin	Jazz/Blues	7	Zone x function	Sprint 3
8	My Funny Valentine	Rodgers & Hart	Jazz	8	Voicing x melody	Sprint 5
9	Just the Two of Us	Withers/Washington	Soul/Jazz	9	Harmonic rhythm	Sprint 4
10	Watermelon Man	Herbie Hancock	Jazz/Funk	10	Voicing x groove	Sprint 6
11	Blackbird	The Beatles	Rock/Folk	11	4D analysis	Sprint 6

#	Song	Artist	Genre	Ch.	Primary Principle	Sprint
12	I Will Always Love You	Parton/Houston	Pop/Soul	12	Convergence	Sprint 9
13	Under the Bridge	RHCP	Rock	13	Tension budgets	Sprint 7
14	Don't Know Why	Norah Jones	Jazz/Pop	14	Section design	Sprint 8
15	Feeling Good	Nina Simone	Jazz/Soul	15	Divergence	Sprint 7
16	Yesterday	The Beatles	Pop/Rock	16	Composition	Sprint 4
17	High and Dry	Radiohead	Rock	17	4D analysis	Sprint 8
18	Fly Me to the Moon	Bart Howard	Jazz	18	Improvisation	Sprint 9
19	Stand by Me	Ben E. King	Soul/Pop	Workshop	Sing-along anchor	Sprint 10
20	La Vie en Rose	Édith Piaf	French chanson	Workshop	World/Oddball	Sprint 11

Oddballs Worth Knowing

Corcovado (Jobim) · Nature Boy (Nat King Cole) · Mercy Street (Peter Gabriel) · Suzanne (Leonard Cohen) · Misty (Erroll Garner) · Scarborough Fair (Traditional/S&G) · Lean on Me (Bill Withers) · Feeling Good — this list is the "people would love these if they knew them" extension of the main repertoire.

Open Slot: The Fifth Foundational System

The AMF framework is designed to accommodate a fifth foundational system. When that system is integrated, it will be added as Chapter 4.5 in Part I of the Textbook and as a new sprint block in the Practice Manual. All cross-system chapters in Parts II and III are structured to accept the fifth dimension. Exercises marked ▲ throughout the textbook will be updated to include the fifth system when it is defined.

AMF — The Adaptable Musician's Framework

This document is a planning and architecture reference for the AMF system.
Book 1 (The Textbook), Book 2 (The Practice Manual), and Book 3 (The
Workbook)
are built from this architecture.

AMF — The Adaptable Musician's Framework · June 2026